

12, The Byzantine Empire Brought About Its Own Destruction

Since Byzantine emperors were utterly incapable of completely domesticating the landlord class as Chinese emperors did, yet simultaneously exhibited blatant hostility toward the nation's **military aristocracy**, the intensification of political struggle and the subsequent crippling of the state's capacity to confront crises were absolute inevitabilities.

In the mid-11th century, the Normans closed in from the West, while the Turks simultaneously advanced from the East. Byzantium had indeed faced myriad enemies in the past, but those were either barbarians just barely transitioning from a tribal state into preliminary **feudalization**, or classical states exactly like Byzantium itself. However, what was now plunging into the empire's heartland were highly organized **feudal military regimes** and **feudalized nomadic empires**!

To a large extent, the Byzantine Empire had managed to survive previously because its eastern neighbors—Persia and the Arab Empire—despite being overtly hostile, were ultimately states possessing **classical characteristics**. For Byzantium, when fighting such regimes, even if territory was temporarily lost, recovering it was not out of the question. However, the increasingly **feudalized** Turks were an entirely different breed of enemy!

The Turks closed in on Anatolia. This not only meant the state faced assaults from **feudal regimes** on both its eastern and western flanks simultaneously, but crucially, the Turks had achieved a degree of **feudalization** that meant they no longer waged war solely for the purpose of plundering populations and wealth. They no longer employed extensive, loose administration over temporarily occupied regions. Instead, **they would firmly control their conquered territories strictly in accordance with (Islamic) feudal relations**! The drastic mutation in this geopolitical landscape precipitated the decline and fall of Byzantium. In the latter half of the 11th century, the entire empire suffered catastrophic, devastating military defeats.

Although Alexios I (阿莱克修斯一世) managed to turn the tide and temporarily stabilize the situation through masterful political maneuvering, one could plainly see that these measures could no longer save the empire. To resolve the contradiction between the emperor and the great aristocratic clans (*to use a Sinicized expression*, 大世族), Alexios resorted to forcing the Komnenos family (科穆宁家族) to deeply bind itself through marriage with other powerful aristocratic houses. Simultaneously, he saturated the bureaucratic apparatus with members of the Komnenos family or aristocrats possessing Komnenian bloodlines.

One cannot say this maneuver was entirely ineffective—after all, for the next three-plus centuries until Byzantium's demise, every Byzantine emperor possessed Komnenian blood. But regarding salvaging the decaying Byzantine state, it was utterly futile. **The aristocratization of the bureaucratic system is fundamentally not synonymous with feudalization**, just as one cannot consider the Eastern Jin Dynasty (东晋) a **feudal regime**!

Another monumental shift in Byzantine policy during Alexios's reign was the introduction of massive foreign assistance. Examples include granting commercial privileges to Italians (*Venetians and Genoese*) and pleading with Catholic Latin states for the Crusades. Judging by subsequent events, this was undeniably the definitive marker that Byzantium could no longer alleviate its crises through its own strength.

By the late Komnenian dynasty, the Byzantine Empire's finances had deteriorated catastrophically. The imperial court found it nearly impossible to levy taxes across the vast majority of its territory,

as massive tracts of land had been usurped by aristocrats and the Church. Furthermore, as Italian merchants established increasingly expansive commercial privileges and built colonial enclaves within Byzantine territory, the empire collected practically zero commercial tax revenue in Constantinople!

Ironically, to maintain the prestigious façade of "Rome," Byzantium required astronomical investments into Constantinople. **Consequently, the great capital of this classical state—the very symbol of urban civic life—had now degenerated into a bottomless financial black hole!**

The imperial fiscal revenue basically equated merely to the private estate income of the Komnenos family's lands. How could this possibly continue to sustain a **classical bureaucratic state**?

The more impoverished the imperial court became, the more its deterrence against the provinces evaporated. The Komnenos family, or the families deeply intermarried with them, monopolized every facet of the empire; it was perfectly normal for several ambitious claimants to the throne to pop up. Thus, the more weakened the empire became, the more ferocious the political struggles grew; and the more ferocious the civil wars grew, the further the empire was weakened. All factions in these political struggles raced to invite foreign powers into the fray, thereby weakening Byzantium even further. The Byzantines had entirely given up any hope of defending their own nation by themselves. The fact that Byzantine emperors repeatedly considered submitting to the Roman Catholic Church in exchange for aid from the Latin world merely to eke out a survival is the ultimate proof of this.

Yet, history staged one final, profoundly thought-provoking spectacle before Byzantium finally exited the stage!

Following the Fourth Crusade's capture of Constantinople, that symbol of the classical bureaucratic empire—and that catastrophic financial black hole—suddenly vanished for the successors of the Byzantine Empire. If we observe the Empire of Nicaea (尼西亚帝国), which would eventually reconquer Byzantium, we discover that this regime heavily resembled the **feudal regimes** established by the neighboring nomadic Turks!

The Nicaean emperor, acting as the supreme commander of this colossal armed nomadic confederacy, completely discarded all that nonsensical baggage about "classical states," "urban civic life," and "bureaucratic systems." He led his royal encampment (行在), constantly moving about the river valleys of western Anatolia. As for Nicaea itself, rather than calling it a capital, it was more accurately a center of religious faith formed because the Ecumenical Patriarch lived there in exile. The emperor's mobile court was absent for the majority of the time, occasionally even crossing the sea to camp in Europe.

This government-in-exile not only occupied the economically developed and densely populated river valleys of western Anatolia, but it completely shed the crushing burdens of a bureaucratic empire required to act like a "true" Byzantine Empire. **Consequently, it erupted with terrifying vitality!** The army of this regime was composed of Turks and hired European knights; cavalry formed its absolute core, with little to no Greek infantry present. At its zenith, it could deploy an army of 20,000 onto the European battlefield. Considering that the overwhelming majority of these 20,000 troops were cavalry, this constituted a formidable force that absolutely could not be underestimated, even in High Middle Ages Europe!

The tragic irony of this story is that the moment this regime recaptured Constantinople—a city the Latin regime itself didn't even want anymore—all the symptoms of the "**Byzantine Disease**," **which the Crusaders had inadvertently "cured," returned with a vengeance, not missing a single one!** Even during the very process of rebuilding Byzantium, the emperor was forced to continue granting trade privileges to the Genoese in exchange for naval support.

The new consciousness that Orthodox Byzantines had developed during their exile (*which possessed distinct **feudal characteristics***)—such as a self-identification as "Greeks" and a militant irredentism (复国主义) emphasizing military struggle—faded rapidly the moment the Byzantine Empire was reconstructed.

From the moment Michael VIII Palaiologos (米海尔八世) abandoned the **feudal** military lifestyle with nomadic traits and trudged back onto the fatal dead-end path of a **bureaucratic state**, all the way down to the Palaiologan dynasty (巴列奥略王朝) in 1453... at least from the perspective of historical lessons, I believe there are absolutely no further stories worth mentioning.

However, we must also neutrally point out that within academia, there remains debate over whether Constantinople was indeed a financial black hole, and if so, *when* it became one. Nevertheless, it is a relatively definitive fact that the financial situation of the Empire of Nicaea was quite healthy, whereas after the Palaiologan dynasty recaptured Constantinople, the state finances continuously deteriorated until they entirely collapsed. Overall, maintaining the late classical imperial system—symbolized by the capital of Constantinople—was, at least fiscally, more detrimental than beneficial to Byzantium.

Some might argue: *The problem wasn't Constantinople; rather, the empire had already lost Anatolia and was thus beyond saving.* The reality is that Constantinople itself was certainly not at fault. But if Byzantine emperors continued to daydream day after day about a universal empire and stubbornly refused **feudalization**, then holding onto Anatolia would have been fundamentally impossible anyway!

Up to this point, by untangling the entire history of the Byzantine Empire, we can explicitly pinpoint its differences from China. The birth and continuation of Byzantium were the outcome of the dual influences of **feudalization** and the counteracting force generated by commercial activities. Barring the Fourth Crusade, Byzantium's classical bureaucratic system existed relatively continuously until its final moments. The impact of **feudalization** upon the Byzantine Empire steadily expanded since its inception and was never genuinely weakened; Byzantine emperors never discovered a systemic method to curb feudalism.

This is starkly different from China, which experienced drastic mutations in its political system during its **feudalization** period and its **restoration-bureaucratic period** (*of course, this is not to say Byzantium experienced no obvious changes, but one only needs to compare it with China to see how exceedingly mild the former's were*). Moreover, the **restoration-bureaucratic state** in China ultimately and completely suffocated any potential challenges posed by the **feudal landlord class**.

Therefore, from the perspective of a Chinese person—though this might seem somewhat biased—I must assert: **The existence of Byzantium as a classical bureaucratic state was dominated by "natural factors."** The nation was propelled toward an unpredictable destiny, and the participants within it, including the emperors, were merely making limited adjustments in passive compliance with shifting tides.

In stark contrast, the Chinese Empire that achieved bureaucratic restoration did so because its rulers **consciously, meticulously, and purposefully utilized every available circumstance and mechanism to reverse the feudalization process via a rigorously oppressive bureaucratic system!** They continuously intensified despotic centralization with the singular goal of transforming everyone aside from the emperor into slaves utterly stripped of power and dignity!

If Byzantium is considered "evil," its depravity never exceeded the boundaries outlined in Machiavelli's *The Prince*—at most, it featured a cunning, battle-hardened monarch exhausting every conceivable machination to consolidate his rule, exactly like Basil II.

But our nation, over the past millennium, has almost successfully actualized the ancient dystopian dream of Lord Shang (商鞅): *To design an institutional machine so absolute that even the most stupid, the most brutal, and the most utterly devoid of morality ruler who acquires power through hereditary succession can utilize the authority bestowed by the system to whip and flog slaves who are vastly smarter and stronger than himself!*

I absolutely refuse to concede that these two types of evil can even be mentioned in the same breath. This is exactly why, while criticizing the Byzantine Empire, I simultaneously defend it: because I do not want anyone to conflate Byzantium with the Chinese Empire!

In fact, one can discover the glaring disparities between the two civilizations even from their surface manifestations. Byzantium undoubtedly relied upon the circulation generated by commerce for its existence. Conversely, the restored Chinese Empire utterly despised *any* circulation that was not strictly controlled by the bureaucratic apparatus (*because such circulation endangers the regime itself. During the Qing Dynasty, this was slightly relaxed because China became enmeshed in the international market*).

(Actually, this is another issue I omitted when previously discussing the Eight Banners state: what the Qing rulers observed when analyzing Ming administration. The Ming Dynasty's political system, during its design and stabilization phases, never accounted for the possibility of massive integration into the global market! This resulted in the late Ming bureaucratic state experiencing a total systemic failure when attempting to control regions like Jiangnan—regions entering the global market, where the forms and scale of commerce and circulation were astronomically beyond what a closed-door state could comprehend. This was obviously a massive catalyst for the political turmoil of the late Ming).

The concept of the *Luyin* (路引 / strict travel permits) is the glaring criminal evidence of **Late Imperial China** attempting to imprison its people within microscopic territorial confines. What sustained a **restoration-bureaucratic state** was not a relatively free market, but the entire bureaucratic apparatus continuously extracting and forcing the unnatural flow of social wealth!

Even though we have seen that Byzantine history does not lack choices (*made by emperors*) similar to those of the Chinese Empire, and Byzantine people, like the Chinese, viewed the systems of a classical empire as "**Towering Mountains**" (重冈俊阜), Byzantium could never have imagined—nor could it ever have executed—what the Chinese Empire did: **Mandating the unnatural deaths of tens of millions of people over five centuries strictly to forcibly provision the highly centralized capital of a despotic empire!** (*The absolute peak population of the entire Byzantine Empire was, at most, 30 million*).

Therefore, to distinguish them by nomenclature: based on the concept of "Late Antiquity" (古典时代晚期) proposed by Western scholars, and considering that Byzantium was formed during this very era, I designate a classical bureaucratic state like Byzantium—which persisted for a massively prolonged period post-classical era—as a "**Late-classical bureaucratic state**" (晚期古典官僚国家). (*We will set the Arab Empire aside for now*).

Finally, I still wish to emphasize that prior to the modern era, agricultural production was the absolute pillar of society and regime in every civilized region of the world, regardless of how crucial commercial revenue might have been to the rulers. Commercial factors can indeed exert a monumental impact on the lifespan of a classical state, **but they can absolutely never alter the fundamental nature of classical society!**

As the history of Byzantium—and the tragic reality of late Byzantine Constantinople deteriorating into an albatross around the empire's neck—amply demonstrates: Even if commerce can effectively hedge against the impact of **feudalization** and significantly prolong a classical society, **the circulation and prosperity it generates are fundamentally insufficient to unlock the doors to modernity!**

I fear this is the greatest, most devastating lesson Byzantium has imparted to humanity thousands of years later!

12, 拜占庭帝国自取灭亡

拜占庭皇帝在不能像中国皇帝一样完全驯服地主阶级的情况下对于全国的军事贵族又表现出了显而易见的敌意，政治斗争激化进而削弱国家面对危机时的能力是必然的。11 世纪中叶，诺曼人从西方，突厥人同东方同时逼近了帝国。拜占庭的确曾经面临过很多敌人，但是那些要么是刚刚从部落状态初步封建化的蛮族，要么就是和拜占庭一样的古典国家，然而现在逼近帝国腹地的却是具有高度组织性的封建军事政权以及封建化的游牧帝国。拜占庭帝国能够延续很大程度上是因为他东侧的邻国长期以来虽然明面上与拜占庭不对付，但波斯和阿拉伯帝国到底是一个具有古典性质的国家。对于拜占庭而言，跟这样的政权作战，即使领地一时丢失也不是没有收复的可能，但是日益封建化的突厥人完全是另一种敌人。突厥人逼近安纳托利亚，不仅让这个国家在两侧都面临封建政权的进攻，而且突厥人已经达到一定程度的封建化使得他们不再只以掠夺人口和财产为目的发动战争，不再对于暂时占领的地区只采取粗放的管理方式，而是会依照（伊斯兰的）封建关系牢牢地控制自己征服的地区。以上形势的急剧变化导致了拜占庭的衰亡，在 11 世纪下半叶，整个帝国遭到了毁灭性的军事失败。

阿莱克修斯一世虽然通过高超的手段力挽狂澜暂时稳定了局势，但是人们明显能看出这些措施不可能再拯救这个帝国。为了解决皇帝与大世族（姑且用一个中国化的表示）之间的矛盾，阿莱克修斯采取了令科穆宁家族与其他强大贵族联姻并且深度绑定的方式，同时让官僚系统内充斥着科穆宁家族以及有科穆宁家族血统的贵族。这个手段不能说没有成效，毕竟接下来三个多世纪直到拜占庭灭亡每个拜占皇帝都有科穆宁家族的血统，但是对于挽救拜占庭国家的倾颓实在无济于事。官僚系统的贵族化并不等同于封建化，就如同人们不能认为东晋是一个封建政权一样。阿莱克修斯执政时期拜占庭政策的另一个重大变化在于引进外援，例如给予意大利人（威尼斯、热那亚）商业特权，向天主教拉丁国家请求十字军东征，从后来发生的事情来看，这的确是拜占庭无法再通过自身力量缓解危机的标志。在科穆宁王朝晚期，拜占庭帝国的财政已经极为恶化，朝廷不但难以向帝国绝大多数领土征税，因为大片土地被贵族和教会所占有。而且随着意大利商人在拜占庭境内的商业特权越来越广泛，殖民地也建立起来，帝国在君士坦丁堡几乎没有商业税的收入了。拜占庭为了维护自己罗马的牌坊，反倒需要对君士坦丁堡进行大量的投入，于是这个古典国家的伟大首都和城市生活的象征，现在沦为了一个深不见底的财政黑洞。帝国的财政收入基本等同于科穆宁家族土地的私产收入，这怎么可能再支撑起一个古典官僚国家呢？朝廷越是贫困，中央对于地方的威慑就越是沦丧，科穆宁家族或者与其深度联姻的家族把控了帝国的方方面面，其中冒出几个对皇位具有野心的宣称者再正常不过。于是帝国越削弱政治斗争越剧烈，而内战越激烈帝国越削弱。政治斗争的各方争先引入外国势力，然后拜占庭又被削弱，拜占庭人对于自己保卫自己的国

家都已经不抱指望了，拜占庭皇帝数次考虑屈服于罗马天主教会以换得拉丁世界的援助以图苟存就是最好的证明。

然而历史却在拜占庭退场之前又上演了一出发人深省的好戏。随着第四次十字军东征夺取了君士坦丁堡，这个古典官僚帝国的象征和财政黑洞对于拜占庭帝国的继承者们来说突然消失了。如果我们观察日后光复拜占庭的尼西亚帝国，就会发现这个政权非常类似于邻近由游牧的突厥人建立的封建政权。尼西亚皇帝作为这个庞大武装游牧团体的统治者，全然不拘泥于什么古典国家、城市生活还有官僚体制这样的怪话，率领他的营帐在安纳托利亚西部河谷地区四处移动。至于尼西亚与其说是首都，不如说是因为普世牧首流亡在此而形成的宗教信仰中心，皇帝的行在大部分时间也不在此处，有的时候还会过海驻扎在欧洲。这个流亡帝国既占据了安纳多利亚西部河谷这一经济发达人口稠密的地区，又完全不需要像一个“真正的”拜占庭帝国一样存在官僚帝国的负担，因而爆发出了极强的生命力。这个政权的军队由突厥人和雇佣的欧洲骑士组成，以骑兵作为主体，少有或没有希腊人步兵的存在。其鼎盛时期能够在欧洲战场投入两万军队，如果考虑到这两万军队绝大多数都是骑兵的话，这即使在中世纪盛期的欧洲也是不可小觑的力量。故事的悲剧之处是，一旦这个政权光复了拉丁政权自己都不想要的君士坦丁堡，那么它曾经被十字军“治好”的“拜占庭病”一个不少的全回来了，甚至在重建拜占庭的过程中皇帝就不得不继续向热那亚人授予贸易特权来换得海军支持。东正教拜占庭人在流亡时期得到发展（一些具有封建特征）的新意识，例如对希腊人身份的自我认同，强调军事斗争的复国主义，等到拜占庭帝国重建的时候又迅速褪去。从米海尔八世放弃了具有游牧特点的封建军事生活重回官僚国家的死路上去，直到1453年的巴列奥略王朝，至少从历史教训的角度来讲，我认为就再也没有值得一提的故事了。

不过我们也中立地指出，有关君士坦丁堡是不是财政黑洞，（如果是的话）什么时候成为财政黑洞在学界有争议。但是尼西亚帝国的财政状况相当健康，而巴列奥略王朝收复君士坦丁堡之后，国家财政持续恶化乃至崩溃是比较确定的事实。总体来看，维持以首都君士坦丁堡为标志的以晚期古典帝国体制，至少从财政上看对拜占庭弊大于利。或许有人说，不是君士坦丁堡有问题，而是帝国已经失去了安纳托利亚，无力回天了。问题在于，君士坦丁堡本身固然无错。但假使拜占庭的皇帝们还一天天在那里做着普世帝国的美梦，顽固地拒绝封建化，那么想要保住安纳托利亚也是不可能的了。

到此为止，通过对拜占庭帝国整个历史的梳理我们就可以很清楚地指出其与中国的不同。拜占庭的诞生和延续是封建化以及商业活动产生的反作用双重因素影响的结果，除了第四次十字军东征以外，拜占庭的古典官僚体制相对连续地存在到了其最后时刻。封建化对于拜占庭帝国的影响自产生以来就逐渐扩大，从来没有被真正削弱过，拜占庭皇帝没有在体制上找到能够遏制封建主义的办法。这与中国在封建化时期以及官僚复辟时期政治体制的剧烈变动（当然不是说拜占庭没有明显变动，但是人们只需要跟中国一对比就知道前者有多么和缓了），以及复辟官僚国家最终完全扼杀了封建地主阶级对其可能造成的挑战截然不同。因此站在中国人的视角，虽然这样可能有些偏颇，但是我还是要说，拜占庭古典官僚国家的存在属于“自然因素”占据主导，这个国家被推向了难料的命运，而参与其中的人们包括皇帝都不过是顺应变化做出了有限的调整。而实现官僚复辟的中华帝国则是其统治者有意识，有计划，有目的地利用可以利用的一切形势和手段用一套严密的官僚制度逆转封建化进程，不断强化专制主义中央集权以图将皇帝以外的所有人都变为没有人的权力和尊严的奴隶。

如果说拜占庭“坏”的话，那么它再怎么坏也没有坏出马基雅维利《君主论》中的范畴，顶多是一个老奸巨猾、精于战阵的君主用尽一切办法增强自己的统治，就像巴西尔二世一样。而我们国家在最近一千年则是几乎成功实践了商鞅当年的愿望：设计这样一个制度，使得通过世袭继承而得到权力的最愚蠢，最残暴，最没有道德的统治者，都有可以用制度赋予他的权位鞭笞除了他以外的，可能远远比他聪明和强壮的奴隶。我绝不认为这两种恶行有任何相提并论的可能，这也是为什么我在批评拜占庭帝国的同时还在为其辩护，这是因为我不想使任何人混淆拜占庭和中华帝国。实际上人们也能够从表象上发现两个文明之间的明显差异，拜占庭无疑依赖商业带来的流通存在，但是复辟的中华帝国则痛恨除了官僚体制严密控制下的一切流通（因为这会危害政权本身，在清代因为中国卷入国际市场，这一点有所放松。实际上这也是之前我在论述八旗国家的时候漏掉的清代统治者在观察明代施政时所看到的另一个问题，那就是明朝的政治体制在设计和稳定的时期并没有考虑到大幅接入世界市场的可能，这就导致晚明的官僚国家在控制江南地区这样开始进入世界市场的，商业和流通的形式和规模远非锁国状态下可比的地区流通情况时出现了失能，这显然是明末政治动乱的一个因素），“路引”这个概念就是晚期中华帝国试

图将人民圈禁在一小片区域的罪证。支撑复辟官僚国家的不是一个相对自由的市场，而是整个官僚体制对于社会财富源源不断地汲取和强迫流动。

就算我们已经看到拜占庭历史上不乏与中华帝国相似的（皇帝的）选择，拜占庭人和中国人一样把古典帝国的体制视为“重冈俊阜”，但是拜占庭不可能想象也做不到向中华帝国一样为了供给一个专制帝国的集权首都在五个世纪间强制性地造成了几千万人口非正常死亡，整个拜占庭的人口最多的时候也就 3000 万。因此现在为了在名称上相区分，我根据西方学者所提出的“古典时代晚期”或者翻译为“晚期古典”这一概念，考虑到拜占庭就形成于此时，因此将拜占庭这样从古典时代往后仍然存在了很长时间的古典官僚国家称为“晚期古典官僚国家”，阿拉伯帝国暂且按下不表。最后，我还是想强调在近代之前，农业生产在全世界任何文明地区都是社会和政权的支柱，哪怕对于统治者来说商业收入再重要也是如此。商业活动的因素确实会对古典国家存在的时间产生重大影响，但是绝对不会令古典社会的性质发生转变。正如拜占庭的历史和拜占庭后期君士坦丁堡已经成为一个累赘的事实表明，商业即使能够对冲掉封建化的影响，使得古典社会延续很久，但是它所创造的流通和繁荣不足以开启近现代的大门，这恐怕是拜占庭给千百年后的人们带来的最大教训了吧！